A Self-Calibrating Single-Camera Pressure Controller for Heterogeneous Urban Traffic: Bounded Fairness, Emergency Preemption and Microsimulation Evaluation

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***Abstract*—Fixed-time signal plans remain the default in many South Asian cities, where traffic is motorcycle-dominated, demand is strongly asymmetric between approaches, and a detector plant is unaffordable. We present RELAY, an adaptive signal controller whose only input is one existing fixed junction camera. A single convolutional detector yields per-approach, per-class counts, converted to passenger-car-unit (PCU) demand and consumed by a queue-weighted pressure controller in the max-pressure family, with the operational rules a deployable signal needs: empty-phase skipping, gap-out, minimum and maximum green, a hard anti-starvation bound, pedestrian demand treated as pressure, and emergency preemption with a bounded hold. The controller estimates each approach's arrival and discharge rate from the counts themselves, with no survey and no configured saturation flow, and uses them to size each green from Webster's cycle on the measured degree of saturation and to price a phase change at the discharge its clearance forfeits. We evaluate against equal-split and demand-optimal Webster fixed plans, plain max-pressure, self-organising traffic lights and vehicle-actuated control in a seeded point-queue simulation, and against Webster, max-pressure and gap-actuated control in SUMO with a motorcycle-dominated fleet and a sublane model. In the point-queue grid of 72 cells across seven demand shapes, two topologies and loads to 2462 veh/h, mean delay falls against the Webster plan in every cell but one, by up to 43.8%, and against actuated control in 64 of 72 cells; the worst cell is analysed and traced to lost time near capacity rather than to the fairness bound. In SUMO the controller reduces delay in every one of 90 paired runs against each baseline, by 22.9% to 55.5% against Webster and 18.1% to 57.4% against actuated control, although at the highest load its worst observed wait is longer than the fixed plans'. A corridor with finite links in SUMO confirms the point-queue finding that the downstream coupling term contributes at most 3.9% of delay. The controller is unaffected by the biased, density-dependent undercount the detector actually exhibits, and emergency preemption reaches green in 4.07 s on average over 900 trials with a worst case of 13.99 s against a closed-form bound of 14.0 s. This is a simulation and real-footage study, not a field deployment.**

***Index Terms*—Adaptive traffic signal control, max-pressure control, computer vision, heterogeneous traffic, emergency vehicle preemption, microsimulation, low-cost intelligent transport systems.**

I. Introduction

URBAN signal control in low- and middle-income cities is usually performed by fixed-time plans or by police officers operating signals by hand. Both allocate green without measuring what is queued. The consequence is visible at almost any asymmetric junction: a busy arterial approach holds a long queue while the crossing minor street receives the green it would receive at three in the morning. Webster's method [1] showed that cycle length and splits should follow demand, but a fixed plan can only follow the demand measured when it was designed, and re-timing surveys are infrequent. Studies of signalised intersections in the Kathmandu valley report saturation flows and delays that differ substantially from standard capacity guidance, attributing the difference to the local vehicle mixture and to lane discipline [2], [3], which is exactly the condition under which a plan imported from a design manual performs badly.

The established remedy is a demand-responsive system such as SCOOT [4], [5] or SCATS [6], or an optimisation-based controller in the OPAC [7] and RHODES [8] lineage. These work and have decades of field evidence, but they assume a detector plant, communications and a control room, so per-junction cost is dominated by sensing and civil works rather than by the algorithm. In a city where the signal head itself is sometimes unpowered, that capital profile is prohibitive.

Two conditions have changed. Fixed cameras are already installed at many urban junctions for enforcement and monitoring, so a camera-based controller reuses a paid-for asset. And single-stage object detectors are now accurate and cheap enough to run at video rate on commodity hardware [9], [10], which makes per-approach counting a software problem rather than a procurement problem. Vision-based queue and density estimation from fixed cameras is established in its own right [11]–[13], and several recent studies connect a detector to a signal timer on this basis [14]–[17].

What is often missing in that applied literature is the control side. Many camera-based studies compute a count and set green in proportion to it, which is a proportional rule rather than a control policy, and they rarely state what prevents a minor approach from being starved, what happens when the detector fails, or how the policy behaves at saturation. They are also usually compared only against a fixed-time plan, which an adaptive controller of any competence will beat. Conversely, the theoretical literature on max-pressure control [18], [19] provides throughput-optimality results in a

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form that assumes ideal queue observation and imposes no minimum green, no clearance interval and no fairness bound, all of which a deployable signal requires.

This paper describes and evaluates RELAY, a controller placed between those positions. Its contributions are:

- A single-camera perception-to-control pipeline for heterogeneous traffic in which presence and PCU-weighted demand are kept as separate quantities, because a PCU-weighted score alone classifies a lone motorcycle as an empty lane.
- A self-calibrating pressure controller. Arrival and discharge rates are estimated per approach from the count sequence alone (Section IV-C) and used for two decisions a constant cannot make: each stage's green is floored at its share of Webster's cycle on the measured degree of saturation (Section IV-D), and a stage change must beat the discharge its clearance interval forfeits (Section IV-E). No saturation-flow table, survey or per-site constant is required. Without these an unconstrained pressure rule terminates every green at the safety minimum once demand approaches capacity and loses to a fixed plan outright.
- Fairness enforced by explicit bounds rather than by the score: separate maximum-wait bounds for vehicles and pedestrians, a cap on the preemption hold, and an anti-starvation rule that serves the worst-treated queue instead of rotating among equally starved ones.
- An evaluation that reports where the controller loses. It is compared against a Webster plan computed from the true mean demand, against three adaptive baselines (plain max-pressure, self-organising traffic lights and vehicle-actuated control), per cell over a 72-cell grid, and in SUMO with a motorcycle-dominated fleet, turning movements and finite links. The count error the detector actually makes, a biased density-dependent undercount, is modelled rather than replaced by convenient zero-mean noise, and the sensitivity to the two parameters the design depends on most is measured.

We are explicit about what this is not. There is no field installation, no controller cabinet in the loop and no before-and-after study on a real signal: control results come from seeded simulation and perception results from recorded footage. The contribution is a design and feasibility study at the level a city could use to decide whether a pilot is worth funding, and Section VII states which claims a field trial would still have to establish.

II. Related Work

A. Fixed-time, actuated and demand-responsive control

Webster's analysis of cycle length and green splits [1] remains the reference method for fixed-time plans and is the basis of the stronger fixed baseline used here. Vehicle-actuated control, in which a green is extended by a passage time on each detected arrival until a gap or a maximum is reached, is the most widely deployed adaptive scheme and is documented in signal timing practice [20]; it is our strongest adaptive baseline. Among demand-responsive systems, SCOOT adjusts splits, offsets and cycle time from cyclic flow profiles measured upstream of the stop line, SCATS selects among plans using measured degree of saturation, and OPAC and RHODES solve a rolling-horizon optimisation over predicted arrivals. All depend on detectors installed and maintained in the carriageway, and all were designed for streams with lane discipline and similar vehicle sizes.

B. Max-pressure and self-organising control

Max-pressure signal control derives from backpressure scheduling in queueing networks [21]. Varaiya [18], [19] showed that repeatedly activating the phase maximising a weighted difference between upstream and downstream queues stabilises any demand within the capacity region using only local queue information, which is attractive for a decentralised deployment. Related work established distributed formulations [22] and decentralised variants with weaker information requirements [23]. Two properties of the theoretical policy conflict with practice. The argmax is evaluated freely at every decision epoch, so the policy may switch as often as the decision interval allows, and each switch costs a clearance interval during which no approach discharges; Levin et al. [24] address this with a cyclical phase structure, and our saturated-demand results are an independent, quantified instance of the same effect. And throughput optimality is proved for the unconstrained policy; adding minimum green, maximum green, hysteresis and forced service breaks the argmax property and voids the proof. We therefore describe our controller as a queue-weighted pressure heuristic in the max-pressure family and make no stability claim.

Self-organising traffic lights [25], [26] are a second decentralised rule that needs only local counts: a red phase accumulates waiting vehicles times seconds and takes green when the integral passes a threshold, unless the current green is discharging a short platoon. It is included as a baseline because it shares our information requirements and is simpler than our rule.

C. Learning-based control

Reinforcement learning is the dominant research direction for signal control. Surveys by Wei et al. [27], Haydari and Yilmaz [28] and Noaeen et al. [29] cover the field; representative works include IntelliLight [30], large-scale decentralised training [31] and PressLight [32], whose reward derives from max-pressure. Genders and Razavi [33] established the basic formulation. We did not adopt a learned policy, for reasons specific to the deployment context: training requires a simulator calibrated to the target junction and none exists for the junctions we are concerned with; a neural policy does not naturally expose the maximum-wait or clearance guarantees an authority approving a signal plan needs; and it transfers poorly across geometries, whereas a pressure rule parameterised only by a phase set moves to a new junction by drawing polygons on a camera image. The comparison we do not make, and which should be made, is a head-to-head against a trained policy on the same arrival streams.

D. Camera-based counting and vision-driven signal control

Vehicle detection from fixed cameras is a mature application of single-stage detectors [9], [10], reviewed by Terven et al. [34], typically trained on general corpora [35] and extended with tracking when trajectories are required [36], [37]. Our system uses the Ultralytics implementation of the YOLO family [38]; the architecture generation we fine-tune is described in [39], which remains a preprint. Because the controller consumes instantaneous per-approach occupancy rather than cumulative crossings, we count detections inside approach polygons instead of tracking vehicles, which removes identity-switch errors in dense queues from the control path.

Recent applied studies pair such a detector with a signal timer. Papanashi et al. [14] report YOLO-based adaptive timing evaluated in Bengaluru, a heterogeneous-traffic context comparable to ours; Alruyshid et al. [15] add emergency and bus prioritisation in a Baghdad case study; Talaat et al. [16] and Medvei et al. [17] report detector-driven controllers, the latter combining detection with a learned policy. These works establish that the perception component is practical. Our contribution relative to them is on the control and evaluation side: an explicit pressure formulation, stated fairness bounds, a preemption latency bound, and an evaluation against demand-optimal fixed-time and actuated baselines that reports where the adaptive policy loses.

Emergency preemption has a long operational history and a careful literature on its side effects, since a preemption interrupts the cycle and can create hazards at the transition [40]; Humagain et al. [41] review route optimisation and preemption methods, and recent work exploits connected-vehicle messaging to grant priority with explicit dilemma-zone protection [42]. Our detection channel differs: the emergency vehicle is recognised visually by the same detector that counts ordinary traffic and no vehicle-side equipment is required. That is an advantage in cost and a disadvantage in reliability, which is why the ambulance class carries the highest confidence threshold and why the hold is capped, and what we add is a worst-case latency bound with a measurement against it.

III. System Architecture

RELAY consists of a perception stage and a control stage connected by one data structure: a mapping from approach identifier to per-class vehicle count. Everything downstream of that mapping is independent of how the counts were obtained, which is what allows the same controller to be driven by recorded footage, a live camera, a synthetic feed, or a microsimulator.

A. Perception

A single fixed camera views the junction. Each approach is a polygon in normalised image coordinates, drawn once per site; no per-site model training is performed. For each frame a YOLO detector produces class-labelled boxes, filtered in four steps. First, per-class confidence gating, because a single threshold is unsuitable for mixed traffic: two-wheelers are small in the image and are lost at a threshold that suppresses false positives on cars, so the system uses 0.24 for motorcycles and bicycles, 0.38 by default, 0.50 for trucks and 0.68 for ambulances. The high ambulance gate is a safety choice: an ambulance detection moves the signal by itself, and a marginal read on a white van would hand the junction to a non-existent emergency, while a vehicle below the gate still contributes ordinary demand through its next-best label. Second, cross-class deduplication, since per-class non-maximum suppression can leave one distant vehicle carrying stacked car, truck and motorcycle boxes: a greedy pass in descending confidence retains a box only if its intersection over union with every retained box is below 0.5. Third, approach assignment by centroid containment, followed by an exponential moving average per approach and class with coefficient 0.35, roughly a one-second time constant at the observed detection rate. Fourth, failure handling: a bad frame returns the last smoothed counts, and a staleness flag set after three seconds without an update makes the pipeline feed the controller empty counts, so the wait clocks and the maximum-wait rule cycle the phases safely instead of holding green on stale demand.

B. Control, topology and deployment

The controller consumes the count mapping and a set of conflict-free phases, and is topology-agnostic: four-arm, three-arm and two-arm junctions differ only in the phase set passed at construction, and approaches may be specified per arm or per movement, in which case the phase set is generated to include paired through phases, paired protected-turn phases and one split phase per arm. Adding a junction therefore requires drawing polygons and declaring phases, not changing code. Pedestrian demand enters as a separate transponder-style input giving, per arm, the number waiting, the longest wait and the number crossing; it is sanitised before use (non-numeric values, unknown arms, negative counts and non-finite waits are discarded, counts clamped to 200 and waits to 180 s) so a client fault cannot inject an unbounded aging term. The intended installation is one small computer per junction, taking a feed from an existing camera and driving the existing signal controller, with no central server in the control path. We measure the perception cost in Section VI-E but claim no cost figure, since no hardware was procured.

IV. Control Formulation

A. Notation and derived quantities

Let A be the set of approaches and P a set of phases, each $p \in P$ a subset of A served simultaneously without conflict. Let Δt be the control step. At each step perception reports counts $n_{a,c}$ for approach a and class c, and the set of approaches on which an emergency vehicle was detected in the current frame. Two distinct quantities are derived, the PCU-weighted demand and the occupancy indicator:

$$d_a = \sum_c w_c \, n_{a,c}, \qquad o_a = \mathbb{1}[\textstyle\sum_c n_{a,c} > 0] \,, \tag{1}$$

with weights w_c from Table I. Keeping these separate matters: a single motorcycle contributes $d_a = 0.3$, which a demand threshold would treat as an empty approach, so the empty-phase skip and gap-out rules key on o_a and a lone two-wheeler still receives a full minimum green.

TABLE I
PASSENGER-CAR-UNIT WEIGHTS w_c IN (1). CONFIGURATION VALUES FOR A MOTORCYCLE-DOMINATED MIX, ORDERED CONSISTENTLY WITH PUBLISHED EQUIVALENCY ESTIMATES FOR SOUTH ASIAN TRAFFIC [43]–[45]; NOT ESTIMATED FROM LOCAL FIELD MEASUREMENTS. THEIR SENSITIVITY IS MEASURED IN SECTION VI-I.

Class	car	m/cycle	bus	truck	amb.	bicycle	auto
w_c	1.0	0.3	2.5	2.5	2.0	0.2	0.8

Each approach carries a clock r_a answering how long the oldest waiting vehicle has waited, not how long since the approach last had green. With G the set of approaches currently green, z_a the consecutive seconds the approach has read empty and $\tau_e = 3$ s,

$$r_a \leftarrow \begin{cases} r_a\,(1-\delta_a) & a \in G, \\ r_a + \Delta t & a \notin G,\ o_a = 1, \\ 0 & a \notin G,\ o_a = 0,\ z_a \geq \tau_e, \\ r_a & \text{otherwise}, \end{cases} \tag{2}$$

where δ_a is the fraction of the approach's demand that discharged during the step. On green the clock unwinds by the fraction of the queue that discharged and reaches zero only when the queue does; resetting it on the green would claim that everything still behind the stop line had stopped waiting, which beyond capacity is false and lets the red phase always hold the older clock. The third case is necessary rather than cosmetic: without it a long-vacant approach accumulates a large clock which the first arriving vehicle inherits, triggering forced service against a loaded corridor. The debounce keeps a detection dropout from erasing a real queue's guarantee.

B. Phase score

Define a bounded urgency multiplier $u_a = 1 + \min(r_a, R)/R \in [1, 2]$, with R the maximum-wait parameter. The vehicle pressure of a phase is

$$D(p) = \sum_{a \in p} d_a\, u_a. \tag{3}$$

Aging multiplies each approach's own demand and is capped at a factor of two, so waiting cannot manufacture demand that does not exist. This is a deliberate departure from an additive term $d_a + \lambda r_a$, which inverts the intended ordering: with $\lambda = 0.4$ a two-vehicle approach that has waited 45 s scores like an eighteen-PCU queue and the controller rotates phases at minimum-green cadence. For the same reason the multiplier is applied per approach rather than at phase level, since a phase-level $\max_a r_a$ lets a starving single-vehicle turn bay double the score of a phase whose large through queue has just been served.

Pedestrians are treated as demand. A phase p frees the crossing of arm x when neither x nor the opposing arm, whose straight-ahead movement traverses the same crossing, is served: $F(p) = \{x : x \notin \text{arms}(p),\ \text{opp}(x) \notin \text{arms}(p)\}$. With m_x people waiting to cross arm x, k_x currently on the crossing and v_x the longest pedestrian wait,

$$\Phi(p) = w_{\text{ped}}\, M(p) \Big(1 + \frac{\min(\bar{v}(p),\ V)}{V}\Big), \tag{4}$$

where $M(p) = \sum_{x \in F(p)} (m_x + k_x)$ counts the people the phase would serve, $\bar{v}(p)$ is the longest wait among them, $w_{\text{ped}} = 0.3$, so one waiting person contributes about as much pressure as one motorcycle, and V the pedestrian maximum-wait parameter. The complete score adds a large emergency constant $B(p) = B_0 \mathbb{1}[\exists a \in p : a \in \hat{E}]$ with $B_0 = 10^6$:

$$S(p) = D(p) + \Phi(p) + B(p). \tag{5}$$

A detection is a per-frame event and detectors drop frames, so each approach carries a hold timer reset to $\theta = 2.5$ s whenever an emergency is announced on that arm and otherwise decaying by Δt; the latched set is $\hat{E}$. Announcements arrive at arm level and every movement key of that arm is latched, because the camera cannot resolve which lane the emergency vehicle occupies.

C. Online estimation of arrival and discharge

Both remaining rules need to know how fast an approach fills and how fast it empties. A fixed-time plan obtains the equivalent from a survey and a saturation-flow table. We estimate both from the count sequence the detector already produces, which keeps the controller free of per-site constants and lets it follow a junction whose behaviour changes with the hour and the weather.

Let $d_a(t)$ be the PCU demand on approach a at step t. An approach on red cannot discharge, so every increase in its queue is arrivals; an approach on green moves by arrivals less departures, so departures are the arrival rate less the observed change:

$$\hat{\lambda}_a \leftarrow \hat{\lambda}_a + \alpha\big(\Delta_a(t) - \hat{\lambda}_a\big), \tag{6}$$

$$\hat{s}_a \leftarrow \hat{s}_a + \alpha\big(\hat{\lambda}_a - \Delta_a(t) - \hat{s}_a\big), \tag{7}$$

where $\Delta_a(t) = (d_a(t) - d_a(t-1))/\Delta t$, (6) is applied on a step during which the approach was red, (7) on a step during which it was green with $d_a(t-1) > 0$, $\alpha = \Delta t/\tau$, and both estimates are clamped below at zero. Three details are necessary rather than cosmetic. The change between two counts was produced under the signal state of the step that has just ended, so the sample is attributed to that state and not to the one being decided; attributing it to the current state charges the first green step with a red step's growth and the first red step with a green step's discharge, and measured 0.49 PCU/s against a true 0.55. The clamp is applied to the running estimate and never to the sample, because per-step counts move in whole vehicles and clamping samples discards only the low side of the noise, inflating $\hat{s}_a$ to 0.79. And (7) is conditioned on the queue held before the step, because whether an approach ends a step non-empty depends on whether a vehicle happened to arrive during it, and conditioning on that deflates the same estimate to 0.30. With all three the estimator recovers 0.51 to 0.60 PCU/s against a truth of 0.55 across demand levels, and $\hat{\lambda}_a$ to within roughly 20%. Both estimates begin at zero, so the two rules below are inert until the junction has been observed for a few cycles; the controller reduces to a plain hysteresis policy in the interim.

D. Green duration from the measured cycle

Webster [1] minimises delay at cycle length $C = (1.5L + 5)/(1-Y)$, where L is the lost time per cycle and $Y = \sum_p y_p$ sums the critical flow ratios $y_p = \max_{a\in p} \lambda_a/s_a$, allocating each phase a green of $(C-L)y_p/Y$. The formula is normally applied offline to survey data. Equations (6) and (7) supply y_p directly, so the same allocation is evaluated continuously from the junction in front of the camera:

$$g^\star(p) = \max\Big(g_{\min},\ (C-L)\frac{y_p}{Y}\Big), \tag{8}$$

$$C = \min\Big(C_{\max},\ \frac{1.5L+5}{1-Y}\Big), \tag{9}$$

with $C = C_{\max}$ when $Y \geq 1$. Y must sum the critical ratios of one cycle, so phases are accumulated heaviest-first over disjoint approach sets; on a movement-level junction the phase sets overlap and summing all of them would invent saturation that is not present. Webster's C diverges as $Y \to 1$ and does not exist beyond it; the clamp at $C_{\max} = 120$ s, the longest cycle a fixed plan would be given, bounds the floor and removes the discontinuity. An earlier version of the controller fell back to $g_{\max}$ there, and with a noisy Y estimate sitting near 1 the floor swung between a green of over 200 s and one of 45 s, the effective cycle shortened, and the extra clearance time was the whole margin at the highest load; Section VI-F reports the cell where this was found.

$g^\star(p)$ is evaluated once, at the instant the phase takes green, and acts as a floor on that green in place of $g_{\min}$ in rule 4 of the stage machine. Evaluating it continuously would chase a target that falls as the queue drains, ending the green for the reason it was extended. It is a floor and not a hold: emergency preemption and the empty-phase skip are evaluated above it and continue to use $g_{\min}$, so nothing waits behind a bound intended for a busy junction. Under light demand Y is small, (8) evaluates below $g_{\min}$, and the rule never binds. It is deliberately not capped at $g_{\max}$, which bounds how long one movement may hold the junction and is a fairness policy; refusing a green the measured demand requires does not protect the minor approaches, because the queue that was not cleared is still present at the next cycle.

E. Pricing a phase change

A phase change costs $y + \rho$ seconds during which no approach discharges. The approaches currently green would have spent that interval discharging, so the challenger must beat the incumbent by more than what the handover forfeits:

$$\kappa(p) = \sum_{a\in p} \min\big(d_a,\ \hat{s}_a(y+\rho)\big), \tag{10}$$

and rule 9 of the stage machine switches only when $S(p^\star) > S(p) + h + \kappa(p)$. The minimum caps the forfeit at what the approach still has queued, so a drained or empty phase costs nothing to leave and the gap-out and empty-phase rules retain their sensitivity. A constant margin cannot express this: h is the same whether the junction is empty or saturated, whereas κ is zero on an empty junction and grows with the traffic actually mid-discharge.

F. Target selection and the stage machine

The signal cycles through green, yellow of duration y and all-red of duration ρ; a green is never followed directly by a conflicting green. The next phase is chosen by strict precedence. *(i) Emergency:* if $\hat{E} \neq \emptyset$, take the phase serving the most emergency approaches, breaking ties by the largest r_a among them. *(ii) Vehicle starvation:* otherwise, if any approach has $r_a \geq R$ and $d_a > 0$, force a phase serving the worst such approach, preferring one that also serves approaches within 25 s of the threshold so that two clearance intervals are not paid where one would do. Candidates are restricted to approaches not currently green whose r_a exceeds that of every approach the current phase serves: this rule serves the worst-treated queue, it does not rotate. Beyond capacity every approach sits past R permanently, and a rule that fires whenever anyone is past the threshold fires on every step. *(iii) Pedestrian starvation:* otherwise, if any arm has $m_x > 0$ and $v_x \geq V$, force a phase in $F(x)$ with the greatest pedestrian demand. *(iv) Score:* otherwise take $\arg\max_p S(p)$ over phases with demand, resting in all-red if none has.

A running green is terminated by the first applicable rule, where e is elapsed green, γ_t the gap-out time, Θ the pre-emption cap, W the walk-hold allowance and h the hysteresis margin:

1) An emergency exists on another phase and not the current one, and either $e \geq g_{\min}$ or the current phase is empty.
2) An emergency exists on the current phase: hold, subject to two bounds. An approach reaching $r_a \geq 2R$ forces service even over an active hold, and the cumulative hold is capped at Θ, after which the emergency term is dropped so the ordinary rules can move the signal.
3) The current phase is empty (no served approach has $o_a = 1$ and no freed crossing has pedestrian demand) while another phase has demand: switch immediately, since an empty phase has no vehicle to strand.
4) $e < g^\star(p)$: hold, with $g^\star(p) \geq g_{\min}$ allocated at onset by (8).
5) Vehicle starvation elsewhere, then pedestrian starvation elsewhere: switch.
6) A pedestrian is still on a crossing freed by the current phase and $e < \min(g_{\max}, g_{\min} + W)$: hold. The bound matters, because an unbounded hold lets a renewing pedestrian stream pin green on a lightly used approach while a loaded corridor waits.
7) Gap-out: the served approaches have read empty for at least γ_t and another phase has demand.
8) Maximum green: $e \geq g_{\max}$, so green is yielded to the best other phase with demand.
9) Score against the cost of switching: $S(p^\star) > S(p) + h + \kappa(p)$ for the best alternative $p^\star$.

Parameter values are listed in Table II.

G. Corridor coupling and the preemption bound

On a corridor each junction j knows, for some arms, the downstream approach (j', a') that the arm's discharge feeds.

TABLE II
CONTROLLER PARAMETERS. THE SINGLE-JUNCTION COLUMN IS USED IN EXPERIMENTS 1, 3, 6, 7 AND 8; THE CORRIDOR COLUMN IS THE CONFIGURATION OF THE SYSTEM'S NETWORK DEMONSTRATION, USED IN EXPERIMENTS 2 AND 9.

Symbol	Meaning	Single	Corridor
$g_{\min}$	minimum green (s)	5.0	5.0
$g_{\max}$	maximum green (s)	30 / 45	34.0
$C_{\max}$	cycle clamp for (8) (s)	120	120
τ	estimator time constant (s)	60.0	60.0
y	yellow (s)	3.0	2.0
ρ	all-red clearance (s)	1.5	2.5
γ_t	gap-out time (s)	2.5	2.5
R	vehicle maximum wait (s)	60.0	26.0
V	pedestrian maximum wait (s)	60.0	60.0
W	walk-hold allowance (s)	12.0	12.0
Θ	preemption cap (s)	60.0	25.0
θ	emergency latch (s)	2.5	2.5
h	hysteresis margin (PCU)	1.0	1.0
w_{ped}	pedestrian weight	0.3	0.3
γ	downstream coupling	n/a	0.4

The demand presented to the score is discounted by the downstream queue $q_{j',a'}$,

$$\tilde{d}_a = \begin{cases} \max\left(d_a - \gamma\, q_{j',a'},\ \varepsilon\right) & o_a = 1, \\ 0 & o_a = 0, \end{cases} \tag{11}$$

with $\gamma = 0.4$ and $\varepsilon = 0.05$, where the floor at ε keeps the coupling a discount on pressure rather than an erasure of presence. This is a one-sided approximation of the pressure difference used in max-pressure theory, where the difference is taken over turning movements; we use the aggregate downstream queue because it is the only downstream quantity one camera per junction can supply.

The worst-case delay from the first emergency detection to green on the emergency approach is bounded by the case in which the announcement arrives immediately after the controller has committed to a transition away from the very phase that serves the emergency. The committed transition completes, the newly served phase must be given its minimum green, and only then can the preemption take effect through a second clearance interval:

$$L_{\max} = y + \rho + g_{\min} + y + \rho. \tag{12}$$

With the single-junction parameters of Table II, $L_{\max} = 14.0$ s. The system also ships an executable self-check asserting twelve properties (clearance, green allocation, fairness, emergency handling and input validation); all pass on the version evaluated and the captured output accompanies the artefacts. These are assertions about behaviour under specified stimuli, not proofs, and say nothing about the perception input.

V. EXPERIMENTAL SETUP

A. Point-queue simulation and baselines

Most control results are obtained in a point-queue simulation, a standard abstraction in which delay accumulates at a single point rather than along a link [46]. While an approach displays green it discharges at $s = 0.55$ veh/s, a saturation headway of about 1.8 s within the range capacity guidance gives for a through lane [47], accumulated as a fractional carry so a green shorter than one headway releases no vehicle, and with no banking of capacity while the queue is empty. Arrivals are Poisson per approach, drawn once per step from a single seeded generator and pushed into every policy's queues, so the comparison is paired at the level of individual vehicles. Runs are 1800 s with the first 300 s discarded, and vehicles still queued at the end are counted with the wait accumulated so far. The value of this abstraction is that the controller under test is the system's own code on identical arrival streams; its cost is traffic-model fidelity, which Experiments 8 and 9 address in SUMO [48].

Five baselines are used. The *equal-split* plan is a round-robin giving each phase 13.0 s of green, a 35 s cycle with 3.0 s yellow and 1.5 s all-red; it represents the demand-blind plans the work aims to replace. The *Webster* plan takes cycle and splits from Webster's formulae computed from the *true* mean demand of the run: with lost time $L = |P|(y + \rho)$ and critical flow ratios summing to Y, the cycle is $(1.5L + 5)/(1 - Y)$ clamped to $[30, 120]$ s, effective greens $(C - L)y_i/Y$ floored at $g_{\min}$, and when $Y \geq 0.95$ the cycle is set to the upper clamp with proportional splits. This baseline is deliberately generous to fixed-time control, being granted perfect knowledge of the average demand and re-derived for every cell. *Max-pressure* is Varaiya's policy as usually simulated: at every step after the minimum green, take the phase with the largest queue, with a clearance interval and no other rule. *SOTL* is the self-organising rule of [25], [26]: a red phase accumulates queue times seconds and takes green when the integral exceeds $\theta = 40$ vehicle-seconds unless the green is discharging fewer than $\mu = 3$ vehicles. *Actuated* is gap-based vehicle-actuated control [20]: green is extended by a 3 s passage time on each arrival up to the maximum green and ends on gap-out, and phases are served in sequence, skipping phases without a call. All adaptive baselines use the same $g_{\min}$, $g_{\max}$, yellow and all-red as the controller.

B. Microsimulation

Experiments 8 and 9 use SUMO 1.27.1 [48] through its TraCI interface. The single junction has four 300 m arms of two lanes each; vehicles go straight with probability 0.8 and turn left or right with probability 0.1 each, turning across the opposing stream under permissive right of way. The fleet is motorcycle-dominated: by count 62% motorcycles, 30% cars, 5% buses and 3% trucks, with SUMO's class dynamics and widths narrowed so two-wheelers share a lane, and the sublane model [49] enabled at 0.8 m lateral resolution so they filter through gaps. Departures are Poisson per arm at the same rates as the point-queue profiles. The controller sees only what a camera would: vehicles by class within 80 m of each stop line, read every 0.5 s; it never reads SUMO's internal queue. Its signal decision is imposed on the SUMO traffic light each step, so yellow and all-red are the controller's own. The Webster baseline is computed from the realised PCU demand of each run and a saturation flow of 1531 PCU/h/lane measured in the same simulation by holding one approach green behind a

standing queue. The actuated baseline is SUMO's own gap-actuated program with a 3 s maximum gap and the same green bounds. Delay is SUMO's per-vehicle time loss against free flow, over vehicles departing after a 300 s warm-up in 1800 s runs, 10 seeds per cell.

C. Experiments

Experiment 1: single junction. A four-arm junction with two phases under three demand profiles. *Asymmetric* sets per-approach rates of $(0.150, 0.130, 0.040, 0.035)$ veh/s for N, S, E and W; *balanced* sets all four to 0.089 veh/s; *single* loads one approach at 0.250 veh/s with 0.035 veh/s on the others. Each profile is scaled by $m \in \{0.6, 0.8, 1.0, 1.2, 1.4\}$, giving 767 to 1794 veh/h, with 30 seeds per cell. Per-seed reductions are compared with a paired t-test and a Wilcoxon signed-rank test. A diagnostic (Experiment 1b) measures phase change rate and displayed-green fraction over 10 seeds per cell.

Experiment 2: three-junction corridor, point queues. A straight arterial carrying a three-arm, a four-arm and a second three-arm junction at 90 m spacing, with the topology, phase sets, routes and timing of the system's network demonstration; link travel time is 7.2 s at 12.5 m/s. Four policies: the controller with coupling (11), the same with $\gamma = 0$, an independent Webster plan per junction, and a coordinated Webster plan with a common cycle and eastbound progression offsets. Runs are 2400 s with 400 s warm-up, 20 seeds, three demand levels, and one emergency vehicle released from the west at $t = 1200$ s.

Experiment 3: preemption latency. The junction is driven to a loaded state for a random interval of 40 to 160 s, after which an emergency vehicle is announced on a random approach and re-announced every step. We record the delay until that approach displays green and replay the identical trial against the equal-split plan, which has no preemption path; 300 trials at each of three demand levels.

Experiments 4 and 5: perception. The shipped detector is evaluated on the system's held-out split, the full stack is run over 60 s of two real fixed-camera clips at 960 px on an Apple M3 Pro, and the count is measured as a function of inference resolution with smoothing disabled.

Experiment 6: robustness grid. Seven demand shapes on the four-way junction plus two on a three-arm T, each at eight load levels running past the point where a fixed plan saturates: 72 cells of 25 paired seeds, reported per cell. The grid is repeated with 20% zero-mean Gaussian miscounting on the counts the controller sees (Experiment 6a) and, in Experiment 6b, under 10 biased count models matching the detector's actual failure: a saturating undercount $q/(1 + q/q_{1/2})$ with $q_{1/2} \in \{8, 4\}$, a flat multiplicative loss of 20, 40 and 60%, and the same losses with a queue of one vehicle rounding to zero so an occupied approach reads empty, with and without a floor of one.

Experiment 7: adaptive baselines. The 72-cell grid with max-pressure, SOTL and actuated control added on the same arrivals.

Experiment 8: SUMO single junction. The three Experiment 1 profiles at $m \in \{0.6, 1.0, 1.4\}$, 10 seeds, against Webster, max-pressure and SUMO's actuated control.

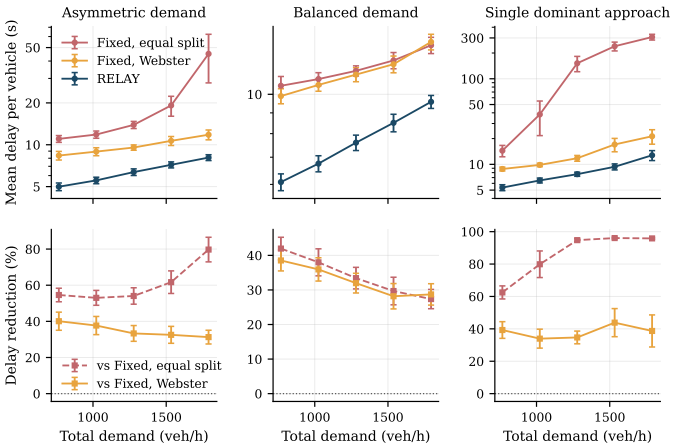


Fig. 1. Experiment 1. Top: mean delay per vehicle against total demand for the three profiles, logarithmic axis. Bottom: paired per-seed reduction against each fixed-time baseline; error bars one standard deviation over 30 seeds.

Experiment 9: SUMO corridor. The Experiment 2 arterial rebuilt in SUMO with 150 m links, so a downstream queue can physically block an upstream discharge; coupled, uncoupled, independent Webster and coordinated Webster, 10 seeds, three levels.

Experiment 10: sensitivity. The fairness bound R from 30 s to unbounded on the single-dominant shape at the two highest loads, and the motorcycle PCU weight from 0.2 to 1.0 with a class-mixed queue whose two-wheeler share differs by axis (80% on N–S, 30% on E–W), so the weight changes which phase looks heavier.

VI. Results

A. Single junction

Table III and Fig. 1 give the single-junction results. RELAY reduces mean delay against both baselines in all 15 cells, by 28.2% to 43.8% against the Webster plan and by 27.4% to 96.0% against the equal-split plan. Under asymmetric demand, the regime the system is designed for, the reduction is 54.0% against equal split and 33.3% against Webster at 1278 veh/h. The gain against equal split grows with demand, reaching 79.7% at 1789 veh/h, but that growth is a capacity artefact: at that demand the equal-split plan is oversaturated on the major approaches and its delay diverges, whereas the Webster plan and RELAY remain stable at essentially the same throughput, 1804 and 1801 veh/h. The gain against Webster is close to flat across the range, 40.1% down to 31.3%; we regard the Webster column as the honest headline.

Under a single dominant approach the equal-split plan collapses: at 1278 veh/h its mean delay is 151.8 s, its mean queue 55.4 vehicles and its throughput 1123 veh/h against the demand offered. Against Webster the gain peaks at 43.8% at 1534 veh/h and is 38.7% at the highest load. Under balanced demand, the hard case for a pressure policy and the case a fixed plan is designed for, the gain against Webster is 38.5% at 769 veh/h and 28.7% at 1794 veh/h.

Fig. 2 shows the wait distribution, which is where the fairness bound becomes visible. At 1278 veh/h under asymmetric demand the 95th-percentile wait is 29.9 s under equal

TABLE III
EXPERIMENT 1. MEAN DELAY PER VEHICLE (S, STANDARD DEVIATION ACROSS 30 SEEDS IN PARENTHESES) AND THE PAIRED PER-SEED REDUCTION ACHIEVED BY RELAY AGAINST EACH FIXED-TIME BASELINE. ALL DIFFERENCES ARE SIGNIFICANT AT $p < 0.05$ BY THE WILCOXON SIGNED-RANK TEST (LARGEST $p = 0$).

	Demand	Mean delay per vehicle (s)			Reduction (%)	
Profile	(veh/h)	Equal	Webster	RELAY	vs equal	vs Webster
Asymmetric	767	11.0 (0.6)	8.4 (0.6)	5.0 (0.3)	+54.6 (3.8)	+40.1 (5.0)
	1022	11.8 (0.7)	8.9 (0.6)	5.5 (0.3)	+53.0 (4.1)	+37.7 (5.0)
	1278	13.9 (0.8)	9.6 (0.4)	6.4 (0.3)	+54.0 (4.5)	+33.3 (4.4)
	1534	19.2 (3.1)	10.7 (0.8)	7.2 (0.4)	+61.7 (6.2)	+32.5 (4.7)
	1789	45.1 (17.2)	11.8 (1.0)	8.1 (0.4)	+79.7 (6.8)	+31.3 (3.8)
Balanced	769	10.5 (0.6)	9.9 (0.4)	6.1 (0.3)	+42.0 (3.3)	+38.5 (3.0)
	1025	10.9 (0.4)	10.5 (0.4)	6.8 (0.3)	+38.0 (3.9)	+35.9 (3.4)
	1282	11.4 (0.3)	11.2 (0.4)	7.6 (0.3)	+33.4 (3.1)	+32.0 (2.9)
	1538	12.1 (0.6)	11.9 (0.6)	8.5 (0.4)	+29.7 (4.0)	+28.2 (3.7)
	1794	13.2 (0.6)	13.5 (0.6)	9.6 (0.4)	+27.4 (2.8)	+28.7 (3.1)
Single	767	14.4 (2.2)	8.8 (0.5)	5.4 (0.4)	+62.5 (4.0)	+39.3 (5.2)
	1022	38.3 (16.6)	9.8 (0.5)	6.5 (0.4)	+79.9 (8.2)	+34.0 (5.8)
	1278	151.8 (30.9)	11.8 (0.9)	7.7 (0.4)	+94.8 (1.0)	+34.7 (3.9)
	1534	239.8 (28.3)	17.1 (3.0)	9.4 (0.8)	+96.0 (0.5)	+43.8 (8.7)
	1789	307.2 (23.7)	21.3 (4.1)	12.8 (1.7)	+95.8 (0.5)	+38.7 (9.9)

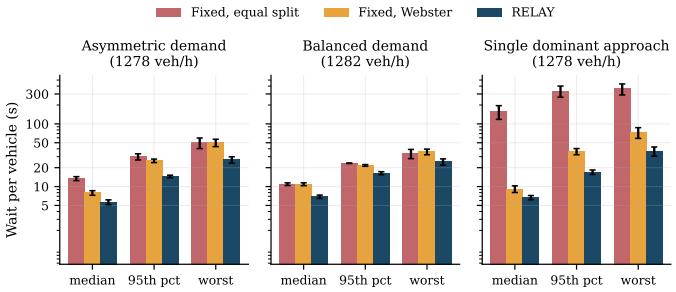


Fig. 2. Experiment 1. Median, 95th-percentile and worst observed wait per vehicle at demand multiplier 1.0, logarithmic axis. The tail is where the anti-starvation bound shows.

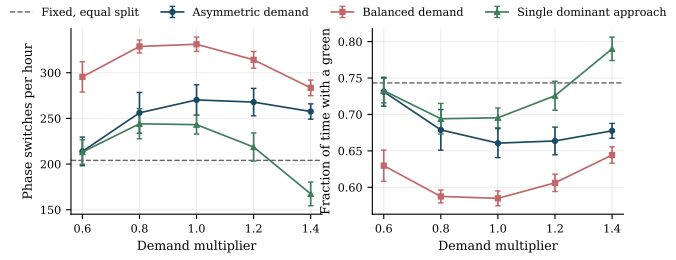


Fig. 3. Experiment 1b. Left: phase changes per hour. Right: fraction of wall time with a green displayed; the complement is clearance. Dashed: the equal-split plan, whose behaviour is independent of demand.

split, 25.8 s under Webster and 14.5 s under RELAY, with worst observed waits of 50.0, 50.1 and 26.7 s. Under a single dominant approach the contrast is larger: 333.4 and 36.3 s at the 95th percentile against 17.0 s, and worst waits of 361.5 and 72.9 s against 36.6 s, consistent with the forced-service rule at $R = 60$ s. The tail improves in every cell, which matters more than the mean for a policy whose fairness claim is a bound.

B. Switching, clearance and what saturation costs

Balanced saturated demand is where an unconstrained pressure policy fails, and the failure motivates three of the rules in Section IV. No phase dominates, so successive scores sit near-tied and any per-step comparison flips on noise. A constant hysteresis margin is crossed almost immediately. An anti-starvation rule that fires whenever any approach has waited past R fires on every step, because beyond capacity every approach is past R permanently. Both terminate green at $g_{\min}$, and the junction is no longer being controlled, only alternated. Measured on this junction at 2307 veh/h, a policy with those two properties displayed 5.2 s of green per 4.5 s of clearance, held green for 0.54 of wall time against the fixed plan's 0.80, and reached 94 s of mean delay against that plan's 19 s. This is the practical form of the issue Levin et al. [24] address with a cyclical structure; Sections IV-D and IV-E recover the lost capacity with a cycle measured rather than configured.

Fig. 3 shows what the resulting policy does. Under balanced demand RELAY switches more often than the fixed plan, 283 to 331 per hour against 204, and displays green for less of the wall clock, 0.585 to 0.644 against 0.743, while reducing delay by 28.2% to 38.5%. Displayed green time is therefore not the objective: a fixed plan spends its green where the demand is not, and slightly less green in the right place beats more of it in the wrong one. Under a single dominant approach at $m = 1.4$ the effects align and RELAY switches less than the fixed plan, 167 per hour, holding green for 0.790 of the time.

C. Corridor, point queues

Table IV contains three findings, one negative. First, the delay reduction is large and decays only gradually with demand: 57.9%, 49.4% and 44.8% against independent Webster plans at 769, 1282 and 1794 veh/h, and 56.2%, 47.8% and 42.3% against the coordinated plan. Through travel time and stops improve together with delay: at the highest demand 32.3 s and 1.87 stops against the coordinated plan's 39.3 s and 2.03, so the gain is not obtained by trading progression for total delay. Second, the coupling term does essentially nothing: disabling it changes mean delay by +0.1%, -0.4% and +0.2% at the three levels. A point queue has no spatial extent,

TABLE IV
EXPERIMENT 2. THREE-JUNCTION CORRIDOR, MEAN OVER 20 SEEDS (SD IN PARENTHESES). DELAY IS TOTAL QUEUEING DELAY PER VEHICLE ACROSS THE JUNCTIONS TRAVERSED; THROUGH TRAVEL TIME IS FOR THE TWO ARTERIAL THROUGH ROUTES (FREE-FLOW 21.6 S); EMERGENCY TRAVERSAL IS THE SINGLE EMERGENCY VEHICLE PER RUN.

Demand (veh/h)	Policy	Mean delay per vehicle (s)	Through travel (s)	Stops per vehicle	Emergency traversal (s)
769	Webster, independent	26.7 (0.9)	39.7 (0.9)	1.95	36.0 (0.0)
	Webster, coordinated	25.7 (0.7)	37.0 (0.7)	1.78	24.5 (0.0)
	RELAY, no coupling	11.3 (0.5)	24.9 (0.5)	1.09	22.3 (3.3)
	RELAY, coupled	11.2 (0.5)	24.9 (0.5)	1.09	22.3 (3.3)
1282	Webster, independent	30.1 (0.8)	41.5 (0.7)	2.09	53.6 (7.5)
	Webster, coordinated	29.2 (1.1)	38.0 (0.8)	1.80	31.5 (0.0)
	RELAY, no coupling	15.2 (0.7)	28.3 (0.6)	1.53	23.7 (4.7)
	RELAY, coupled	15.2 (0.6)	28.5 (0.6)	1.53	23.5 (4.7)
1794	Webster, independent	36.7 (3.3)	43.1 (1.3)	2.10	30.1 (6.5)
	Webster, coordinated	35.3 (3.6)	39.3 (0.9)	2.03	24.0 (0.0)
	RELAY, no coupling	20.2 (0.8)	32.1 (0.7)	1.87	27.6 (8.5)
	RELAY, coupled	20.2 (0.8)	32.3 (0.7)	1.87	26.7 (8.3)

TABLE V
EXPERIMENT 3. DELAY FROM FIRST EMERGENCY DETECTION TO GREEN ON THE EMERGENCY APPROACH OVER 900 TRIALS. THE EQUAL-SPLIT BASELINE HAS NO PREEMPTION PATH; ITS LATENCY IS SET BY CYCLE POSITION AND IS POOLED.

Demand	Policy	Mean	SD	Median	95th pct	Worst
Light (m=0.6)	RELAY	4.02	3.56	4.59	10.80	13.61
Medium (m=1.0)	RELAY	4.04	3.88	4.27	11.83	13.91
Heavy (m=1.4)	RELAY	4.16	3.86	4.53	11.85	13.99
All	RELAY	4.07	3.76	4.53	11.33	13.99
All	Equal split	7.00	7.04	5.02	20.59	22.29

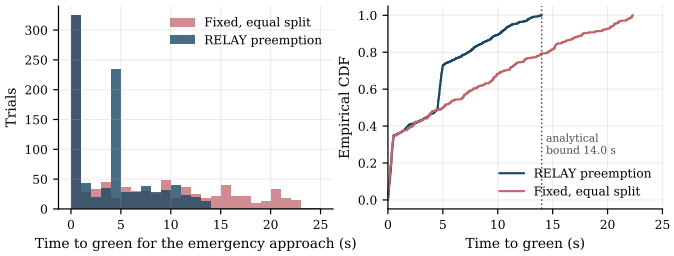


Fig. 4. Experiment 3. Left: time from first emergency detection to green, 900 trials. Right: empirical cumulative distributions against the bound of (12).

so a downstream queue never physically blocks an upstream discharge, which removes the main mechanism the coupling addresses; Experiment 9 tests the same question with links that can fill. Third, the emergency vehicle traverses the corridor in 22.3 to 26.7 s under RELAY against a free-flow reference of 21.6 s, so it is delayed by a few seconds across three junctions, against 30.1 to 53.6 s under independent Webster plans. The coordinated plan does well here, 24.0 to 31.5 s, because the vehicle travels in the progression direction; a westbound emergency would not benefit, whereas RELAY is direction-agnostic by construction.

D. Emergency preemption latency

Mean latency is 4.07 s against 7.00 s for the fixed cycle, and is almost insensitive to demand, 4.02 s at the lightest load and 4.16 s at the heaviest (Table V). That insensitivity is a design property: the green allocated by (8) grows with saturation, but preemption is evaluated above it against $g_{\min}$, so a busier junction does not make an emergency vehicle wait longer. The important quantity is the tail: the 95th percentile is 11.33 s against 20.59 s and the worst case over 900 trials is 13.99 s against 22.29 s. The measured worst case sits just below the analytical bound of 14.0 s from (12), and inspecting the worst trials confirms the mechanism, since every trial above 13.4 s is one in which the announcement arrived within the first second of a yellow already transitioning away from the emergency's own phase. Because the bound is composed only of clearance and minimum-green settings, it can be stated in advance to an emergency service. Two qualifications belong here: in 34.6% of trials the emergency approach already had green when the vehicle was detected, and in 33.1% the fixed cycle happened to reach that approach sooner than the preemption did, which is why the distributions overlap in Fig. 4 even though tail behaviour differs sharply. The claim these data support is a bounded worst case, not a uniformly faster response.

TABLE VI
EXPERIMENT 4. DETECTOR PERFORMANCE ON THE HELD-OUT SPLIT: 97 IMAGES, 4990 LABELLED INSTANCES, 2.59-MILLION-PARAMETER CHECKPOINT.

mAP@50	mAP@50–95	P	R	car	m/cycle	bus	truck	amb.
0.954	0.809	0.950	0.886	0.985	0.851	0.981	0.964	0.987

E. Perception

Table VI reports mean average precision of 0.954 at IoU 0.5 and 0.809 averaged over IoU 0.5 to 0.95. Per-class average precision exceeds 0.96 for cars, buses, trucks and ambulances and is lowest for motorcycles at 0.851, the expected ordering given that two-wheelers are the smallest and most occluded class. An important caveat concerns the split: it mixes automatically labelled frames from a synthetic feed with real frames pseudo-labelled by a general detector rather than by human annotation, so a high score establishes that the fine-tuned model reproduces the labelling function it was trained against, not accuracy against human ground truth, and the

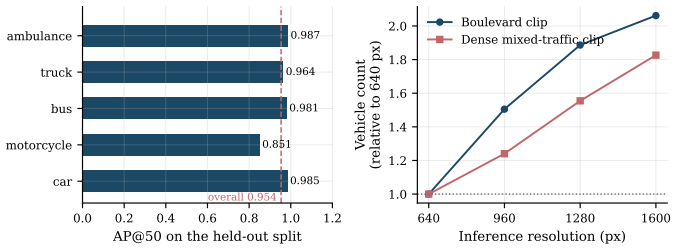


Fig. 5. Experiment 4. Left: per-class AP at IoU 0.5. Right: sampled count against inference resolution, normalised to 640 px. Neither curve has flattened by 1600 px.

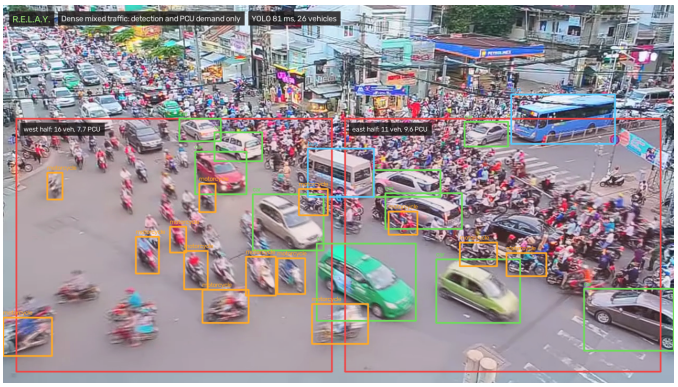


Fig. 6. Experiment 4. The stack on dense motorcycle-dominated footage. The failure mode is visible: a few dozen vehicles are detected in a scene containing several hundred, so the reported PCU demand is a severe underestimate. This is the error Experiment 6b models.

ambulance figure reflects a class that is easy to separate in the synthetic domain.

Running the full stack on real footage at 960 px, median per-frame latency is 46.8 ms on the boulevard clip (21.4 frames per second, 95th percentile 85.7 ms) and 87.6 ms on the dense mixed-traffic clip (11.4 frames per second); the first frame costs 1735 ms of one-off initialisation. Both rates exceed what the control loop needs, since decision epochs are governed by the 5 s minimum green rather than by frame rate, and perception is decoupled from control so a latency spike delays a count update rather than a decision.

Fig. 6 shows the main perception weakness. To quantify it we measured how the count changes with inference resolution (Fig. 5, right). On the dense clip the mean sampled count rises from 21.4 at 640 px to 26.5 at 960 px, 33.2 at 1280 px and 39.0 at 1600 px, an increase of 83% with no sign of convergence, and motorcycles alone rise by 120%; on the sparser boulevard clip the count rises from 4.85 to 10.00. A count that keeps growing with resolution has not converged, so the absolute demand values the controller receives on dense two-wheeler scenes are underestimates of unknown magnitude, and the undercount is worse where the queue is denser. Median inference cost rises from 47.2 to 108.0 ms over the same range. This does not immediately invalidate the control results, because the controller compares approaches rather than reading absolute volumes; Experiment 6b measures how much it matters.

F. Robustness across demand shapes, topology and count error

Table VII reports the wider grid. RELAY reduces mean delay against both fixed-time baselines in 72 of 72 cells spanning 432 to 2462 veh/h, and never falls below 26.9% against the equal-split plan. The worst cell against Webster is the single-dominant shape at 2300 veh/h, where the reduction is 1.4%: 61.2 s of mean delay against 61.4 s, at throughputs of 2221 and 2238 veh/h. There the dominant approach alone demands 82% of all displayed green, the demand-optimal cycle is over 260 s, the Webster reference is granted its 120 s clamp and is itself unstable, with a residual queue at the end of the window, and neither controller serves the demand.

This cell is worth dwelling on because an earlier version of the controller lost it by 26.6%, and the explanation we first gave was wrong. We attributed the loss to the fairness bound R, reasoning that no cycle short enough to respect a 60 s maximum wait is stable at that load. Experiment 10 then swept R from 30 s to unbounded and the delay did not move (Section VI-I). The actual mechanism was in (8): with the measured Y fluctuating around 1, the earlier fallback to $g_{\max}$ above $Y = 1$ alternated the floor between a green of over 200 s and one of 45 s, the controller ran a shorter effective cycle than the 120 s plan, and at a degree of saturation of 0.93 the extra 3% of time spent in clearance was the entire margin. Clamping the measured cycle at $C_{\max}$, exactly as the fixed plan is clamped, removed the discontinuity and brought the cell to within a few per cent of the plan with no other cell worse. We report the sequence because it is the kind of error a per-cell evaluation exists to catch, and because a mean over the grid would have hidden it.

Repeating the grid with 20% zero-mean Gaussian miscounting leaves the picture unchanged, 71 of 72 cells won with a worst cell of -8.1% against Webster. That test is weak, because the estimators smooth over a $\tau = 60$ s window that averages zero-mean noise away. Experiment 6b applies the error the detector actually makes. Table VIII shows the controller is unaffected by a saturating undercount and by a flat multiplicative loss down to 40% of the true count, because the degree of saturation in (8) is a ratio of arrival and discharge estimates drawn from the same counts, so a uniform scale factor cancels, and the phase comparison in (5) is invariant to a common scale. It collapses only when a lone vehicle rounds to zero and an occupied approach reads empty, because the empty-phase skip and the wait clock are keyed on presence; giving presence a floor of one restores the result completely. The requirement this yields for the perception stack is narrow and testable: the controller needs an unbiased presence signal at short queues, not accurate absolute counts.

G. Adaptive baselines

Fig. 7 adds the adaptive baselines on the same grid. Against plain max-pressure RELAY wins 72 of 72 cells with a worst of $+9.1\%$ and a median of 20.8%; against SOTL 72 cells, worst $+5.8\%$, median 12.1%. Vehicle-actuated control is the serious competitor: RELAY wins 64 of 72 cells with a median reduction of 9.3%, and loses 8 cells, all at or beyond capacity

TABLE VII
EXPERIMENT 6. WORST AND MEDIAN PAIRED DELAY REDUCTION OVER THE EIGHT LOAD LEVELS OF EACH DEMAND SHAPE, 25 SEEDS PER CELL. THE WORST COLUMN IS THE REPORTABLE ONE.

Topology	Shape	Worst vs equal	Worst vs Webster	Median vs Webster
Four-way	Asymmetric	+53.2	+29.0	+33.7
	Balanced	+26.9	+26.9	+30.5
	Near-equal	+27.9	+27.7	+30.8
	One axis	+63.4	+29.2	+37.3
	Three heavy	+32.9	+34.1	+35.0
	Lopsided	+52.6	+33.8	+35.4
	Single	+61.3	+1.4	+37.7
T	Balanced	+36.8	+36.2	+38.8
	Arterial	+63.1	+30.4	+38.4

TABLE VIII
EXPERIMENT 6B. THE 72-CELL GRID UNDER BIASED COUNT MODELS APPLIED TO WHAT THE CONTROLLER SEES. CELLS WON MEANS A POSITIVE REDUCTION AGAINST BOTH FIXED PLANS.

Count model	Cells won	Worst vs Webster (%)	Mean vs Webster (%)
Saturating, $q_{1/2} = 8$	71/72	−8.9	+36.0
Saturating, $q_{1/2} = 4$	71/72	−22.1	+35.3
Scale 0.8	71/72	−0.0	+36.6
Scale 0.6	72/72	+0.9	+36.6
Scale 0.4	51/72	−36.6	+3.9
Scale 0.8, lone vehicle reads 0	50/72	−36.6	+3.8
Scale 0.6, lone vehicle reads 0	50/72	−36.6	+3.9
Scale 0.8, presence floor 1	71/72	−0.0	+36.6
Scale 0.6, presence floor 1	72/72	+0.9	+36.6

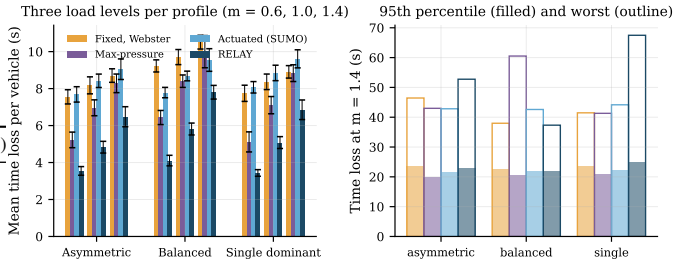


Fig. 8. Experiment 8. Left: mean time loss per vehicle in SUMO by policy and demand. Right: 95th-percentile and worst time loss at the highest load, where RELAY's tail is no longer the shortest.

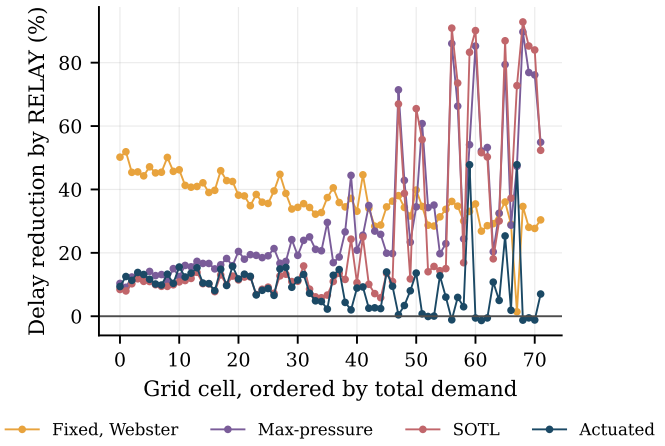


Fig. 7. Experiment 7. Paired delay reduction of RELAY against each baseline over the 72 cells, ordered by demand. Positive favours RELAY.

on balanced or near-balanced shapes, by at most 1.3%. The mean advantage over actuated control is modest, and we say so; the difference lies in the tails. Averaged over the grid, the 95th-percentile wait is 20.2 s under RELAY against 24.1 s under actuated control, 49.6 s under max-pressure and 61.4 s under SOTL, and the worst wait 35.4 s against 36.2, 74.9 and 77.1 s. Max-pressure and SOTL have no fairness bound, and their tails show it; actuated control's sequential service gives it a bound of its own, which is why it is close on the tail and why the honest summary is that RELAY is an actuated controller that does not need detectors in the road, sizes its greens from a measured cycle, and carries preemption.

H. Microsimulation

Table IX and Fig. 8 give the microsimulation result. RELAY reduces mean time loss in every one of the 90 paired runs against each of the three baselines: by 22.9% to 55.5% against the Webster plan, 21.5% to 36.1% against max-pressure, and 18.1% to 57.4% against SUMO's actuated program. The margin over actuated control is larger here than in the point-queue harness, and the reason is visible in the traffic: with a motorcycle-dominated fleet a gap-actuated detector sees a continuous stream of small headways and extends green to its maximum on the busy approach, whereas the measured-cycle floor sizes the green to the degree of saturation and hands over sooner. The reduction falls with load in every profile, from about 55.5% at the lightest to 22.9% at the heaviest, as it does in the point-queue grid.

One result goes the other way and must be reported. At the highest load the worst observed time loss is 52.5 s under RELAY against 42.0 s under Webster and 43.2 s under actuated control, averaged over the three profiles, and the 95th percentile is 23.3 s against 23.2 s. In the point-queue harness the fairness bound held the tail; in SUMO it does not, because the bound applies to what the camera sees. A vehicle beyond the 80 m detection zone is not on any wait clock, and under saturation the queue extends past the zone, so the vehicles that wait longest are precisely the ones the controller cannot count. This is a real limitation of camera-based control with a fixed field of view and it is the strongest argument in these results for a wider or second camera at a junction expected to saturate. At light and moderate load, where the queue sits inside the zone, the tail is shortest under RELAY (11.8 s against 22.4 s

TABLE IX
EXPERIMENT 8. SUMO, MEAN TIME LOSS PER VEHICLE (S, SD OVER 10 SEEDS) AND PAIRED REDUCTION OF RELAY AGAINST EACH BASELINE.

	Demand	Mean time loss (s)				Reduction (%)		
Profile	(veh/h)	Webster	Max-pr.	Actuated	RELAY	vs Web.	vs M-p.	vs Act.
Asymmetric	767	7.6 (0.4)	5.2 (0.4)	7.7 (0.4)	3.5 (0.2)	+53.0	+31.8	+53.7
	1278	8.2 (0.5)	7.0 (0.4)	8.4 (0.4)	4.8 (0.3)	+40.9	+30.5	+42.6
	1789	8.7 (0.4)	8.3 (0.5)	9.0 (0.6)	6.5 (0.5)	+25.5	+21.8	+28.4
Balanced	769	9.2 (0.3)	6.4 (0.4)	7.8 (0.3)	4.1 (0.3)	+55.5	+36.1	+47.2
	1282	9.7 (0.4)	8.4 (0.3)	8.7 (0.3)	5.8 (0.3)	+40.1	+30.8	+33.0
	1794	10.5 (0.4)	10.0 (0.9)	9.5 (0.6)	7.8 (0.4)	+25.8	+21.5	+18.1
Single	767	7.7 (0.4)	5.1 (0.5)	8.1 (0.3)	3.4 (0.2)	+55.5	+32.4	+57.4
	1278	8.4 (0.4)	7.1 (0.5)	8.8 (0.4)	5.1 (0.3)	+39.1	+28.4	+42.6
	1789	8.9 (0.3)	8.8 (0.5)	9.6 (0.5)	6.9 (0.5)	+22.9	+22.3	+28.5

TABLE X
EXPERIMENT 9. SUMO CORRIDOR WITH 150 M LINKS, MEAN TIME LOSS PER VEHICLE (S, SD OVER 10 SEEDS) AND ARTERIAL THROUGH TRAVEL TIME (S).

Demand (veh/h)	Policy	Mean time loss (s)	Through travel (s)
769	Webster, independent	22.2 (1.0)	93.3
	Webster, coordinated	20.8 (0.7)	91.0
	RELAY, no coupling	6.9 (0.5)	78.7
	RELAY, coupled	6.7 (0.5)	78.5
1282	Webster, independent	23.3 (0.4)	94.3
	Webster, coordinated	22.6 (0.8)	92.7
	RELAY, no coupling	10.9 (0.6)	79.9
	RELAY, coupled	10.8 (0.5)	80.0
1794	Webster, independent	26.6 (1.2)	96.0
	Webster, coordinated	26.0 (2.0)	93.5
	RELAY, no coupling	17.2 (1.8)	82.3
	RELAY, coupled	17.9 (1.7)	82.4

at the lightest load).

Table X settles the coupling question the point-queue corridor left open. With links short enough that a downstream queue physically blocks an upstream discharge, disabling the coupling term changes mean time loss by +1.5%, +1.4% and -3.9% at the three levels, at most 3.9%. The corridor gain over the coordinated Webster plan, 31.2% to 67.6%, is therefore attributable to local adaptivity alone in both traffic models. The aggregate downstream queue is too weak a proxy for the movement-specific pressure difference of max-pressure theory to add anything measurable, and the design would lose nothing by dropping it.

I. Sensitivity

Fig. 9 gives the two sensitivities. The fairness bound R does not move the mean at all on the single-dominant shape: from 30 s to unbounded, mean delay stays between 12.7 and 12.7 s at 1789 veh/h and between 61.1 and 61.7 s at 2300 veh/h, with the reduction against Webster between +0.9% and +1.5% at the higher load. The worst wait is likewise flat, 80 to 80 s, because at this shape the measured-cycle floor, not the starvation rule, determines when the minor approach is served. R binds where the score would otherwise leave a small queue unserved, which is the light-load case Fig. 2 shows, not the saturated one. The motorcycle weight, with two-wheeler shares that differ by axis, changes the reduction against Webster

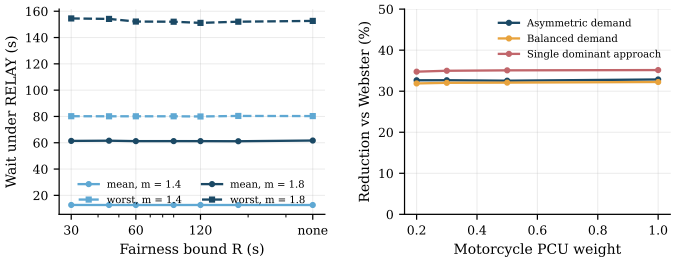


Fig. 9. Experiment 10. Left: mean and worst wait against the fairness bound R on the single-dominant shape at 1789 and 2300 veh/h. Right: reduction against Webster as a function of the motorcycle PCU weight with a two-wheeler share of 80% on one axis and 30% on the other.

by at most 0.4 percentage points across the three shapes (asymmetric +32.6% to +32.9%). A weight of 1.0, which treats a motorcycle as a car, is the worst setting on the axis-imbalanced mix, but the controller degrades gracefully because it compares phases rather than reading absolute volumes and because the measured-cycle floor is a ratio in which a per-class weight partly cancels.

VII. LIMITATIONS

This is not a field study. No signal was controlled. There is no cabinet in the loop, no communication with a real controller and no before-and-after measurement, so we have no evidence about the failure modes that appear only in the field: power interruption, lens contamination, camera repositioning, seasonal light changes, or drivers who learn that the signal responds to them.

The fairness bound applies to the visible queue. Experiment 8 shows that at saturation the vehicles waiting longest are beyond the detection zone. Any camera-based controller shares this, and it should be stated to an authority as a condition on camera placement rather than hidden in a mean.

Perception was not validated against human ground truth. The held-out split mixes synthetic frames with pseudo-labelled real frames, so mAP measures agreement with the labelling process. Experiment 6b bounds the consequence for control under structured undercounting, but the magnitude of the undercount on the target city's junctions is unknown and a human-annotated set is required before any absolute demand claim.

The microsimulation is calibrated to SUMO defaults, not to a Kathmandu junction. The fleet shares and vehicle dynamics are plausible for the region but were not fitted to local measurements, the saturation flow was measured in the simulator rather than on the road, and the corridor geometry is the demonstration's, not a surveyed one. The SUMO results establish that the controller's advantage survives car-following, lane changing, turning conflicts and spillback; they do not establish its magnitude at any particular site.

Narrower gaps. The evaluated junctions have two stages, so movement-level phasing and protected turns are generated but not exercised. The natural research baseline for a pressure controller is a learned policy, PressLight [32] in particular, and that comparison is not made. The pedestrian logic is asserted by executable invariants but never compared against a conventional pedestrian stage, so we report its behaviour and not its benefit. The corridor coupling term should be removed or replaced by a movement-level pressure difference, since neither traffic model supports it.

VIII. Conclusion

We have described a single-camera adaptive signal controller for heterogeneous urban traffic and evaluated it in a seeded point-queue simulation, in SUMO with a motorcycle-dominated fleet, and on real fixed-camera footage. The controller converts per-approach, per-class detections into PCU-weighted demand and selects phases by a queue-weighted pressure score in the max-pressure family, with clearance intervals, minimum and maximum green, empty-phase skipping, gap-out, a hard maximum-wait bound for vehicles and a separate one for pedestrians, and emergency preemption with a bounded hold. Its distinguishing feature is that it measures the junction rather than being told about it: arrival and discharge rates estimated from the same counts the detector produces size each green from Webster's cycle on the measured degree of saturation and set the margin a competing phase must clear.

Against a fixed plan granted the true mean demand the controller reduces mean delay in every cell of the primary grid and in 72 of 72 cells of the robustness grid, the remaining cell being at parity beyond capacity; it beats plain max-pressure and self-organising control everywhere, and vehicle-actuated control in 64 of 72 cells with a markedly shorter tail. In SUMO it reduces time loss in every paired run against Webster, max-pressure and actuated control, by 22.9% to 55.5% against the fixed plan, while its worst-case wait at saturation is longer than the fixed plans', because the fairness bound reaches only as far as the camera sees. The controller is unaffected by the biased undercount the detector exhibits as long as an occupied approach never reads empty, and emergency preemption reaches green within a closed-form bound in 900 trials. Two negative results are reported: the corridor coupling term contributes nothing in either traffic model, and an explanation we first offered for the one weak cell was wrong and is replaced by a measured one. The next steps follow from the limitations: a human-annotated perception set from the target city, a comparison against a learned policy on identical arrivals, and a field trial.

Data and Code Availability

The controller, perception stack, simulation harness, SUMO harness, experiment scripts, raw per-run result files and figure and table generators are available at https://github.com/kafle1/relay under the AGPL-3.0 licence. Every number in this manuscript is a macro generated from the raw result files by experiments/make_numbers.py, and experiments/verify_claims.py regenerates and checks them.

Declarations

The author declares no competing interests and received no funding. No human subjects or personal data were involved: the footage is publicly available recorded video of public roads, used only for aggregate counting, and no identification of individuals or vehicles was performed or attempted.

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